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Highland plateau Amhara of Ethiopia

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5.2.2 Sex in Amhara culture

The extension of the concept of "temporary wife" to prostitution has already been touched upon in connection with the entertainment aspect of sex. It is this extension which imposes on this activity a characteristic culture pattern, involving the "unattached woman's" hoping to find another husband, and meanwhile serving transient travellers with food, shelter, and even some wifely affect. In return for this partial constraint, the culture pattern rewards the "unattached woman" prostitute with certain minimal respectability. She may actually break the curse of barrenness of a first marriage by bearing a child, thus finding it easier to find another husband. She also has the chance to experiment in sex, learning from travellers, and teaching the local townsmen and peasants. There are several terms meaning prostitute: [unknown]s[unknown]rmut'a, an Arabic loanword; gal[unknown]mota (woman no longer a virgin); am[unknown]nz[unknown]ra (fornicator); lag[unknown]rb[unknown]kk'a, lit. for the country sufficient, public woman. There are also references to "loose personality, e.g. sess[unknown] [unknown]a set, considered as insulting.

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A strong constraint placed on the temporary wife - prostitute, as on any other Amhara, is against her sexual intercourse with a Muslim. Infraction of this rule would bring immediate and severe ostracism. Since many of her potential clients are travelling traders, many of whom are Muslims, the temptation is strong to ignore that rule. But if she does, she can seek reinstatement in Orthodox Amhara society, which she is considered to have renounced in consummating a union with a Muslim. This is done by appealing penitently to her confessor, who may then agree to re-baptize her, which is considered a

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necessary rite in this case. This will lift the ban of ostracism against her, on her social level.

This religious ban against sexual intercourse with a non-Orthodox occasionally affects non-prostitutes also. Arab traders, particularly, like to joke with Orthodox Amhara women when the latter come to their stores; e.g., teasingly refusing to hand over goods after purchase has been made, or if the customer finds the price on a desired item too high, suggesting that payment might be made "another way". These fixed stores, located near the daily or Saturday markets, feature luxuries rather than what are considered necessities; e.g. sandals, tea, sugar, raisins, necklaces, imported chocolate, etc. A woman deserted by her husband, or divorced, might succumb. On the other hand, Muslim women are much more segregated from menfolk, so that there is little opportunity for an Amhara male to break the rule with a Muslim female.

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Being a virgin (d[unknown]ng[unknown]L) is expected of girls at first marriage, which occurs about the age of fourteen or fifteen. If she is found by the husband not to be a virgin, and he feels sure of it and insists on his rights, he can divorce her, or go to court against her kinfolk claiming damages as high as \$200-500. This is rare, however, for at that age most girls are too young to have had much opportunity for  270 complete sexual intercourse. The courtship, apart from the above-described occasions during watch in the fields and on festivities - when they are very formal - consists of what adults condescendingly and smilingly refer to as m[unknown]ddarat, love-whisperings, considered adolescent, during which the boy and girl alternate between childish whisperings and play-ful hitting at each other. The term is not used for love-making of adults or married couples.

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